Sparse Retrieval Adapters for Low-Resource Clinical Question Answering

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Abstract

Clinical question answering systems struggle in hospitals that cannot share patient records with large hosted models. We study sparse retrieval adapters, small learned modules that re-weight a BM25 index using fewer than two million parameters, and show that they recover most of the gain of dense retrieval at a fraction of the memory cost. On three public benchmarks (MedQA-USMLE, PubMedQA and BioASQ-9b) our adapters improve exact-match accuracy by 4.1 to 7.8 points over a tuned BM25 baseline while running on a single CPU. We further find that adapters trained on one hospital's discharge notes transfer to a second hospital with a loss of under one point. We release code and trained adapters to support privacy-preserving deployment.

Keywords: retrieval augmentation, clinical NLP, parameter-efficient learning

1 Introduction

Retrieval-augmented generation has become the default recipe for grounding answers in source documents, yet the dense retrievers it relies on are expensive to host and to update. In regulated settings such as hospitals, models often have to run on modest on-premise hardware, and the corpus changes daily as new notes are written. Sparse lexical retrieval remains attractive in this setting because its index is cheap to rebuild, but its accuracy lags behind dense methods on paraphrased clinical questions.

This paper asks how much of that gap a very small learned component can close. Our contributions are a simple adapter architecture, an analysis of when it helps, and a cross-site transfer study.

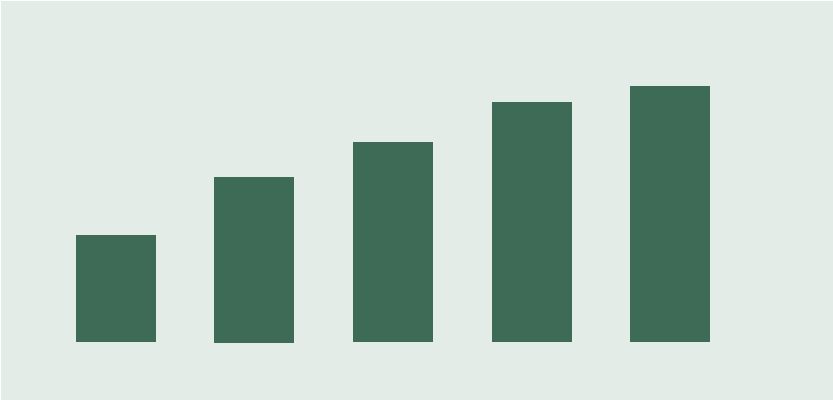


Figure 1: Exact-match accuracy as adapter size grows (0.1M to 2M parameters).